r/aiwars

I have done the math: AI uses too much water.

Posted by u/StainedToilet • • 0 points • 3 comments

So, i have done the math. Image is the websites where i got the data from, DM for sources.

I have made a few estimates and assumptions that are all within reach. (and a bit generous too)

This is based off the assumption that an AI image uses about as much water as a toilet flush.

Based on the fact that the federal standard for a toilet flush in America is 1.6 gallons (or around 26 cups, which i will be using), along with the current population of DefendingAiArt (53 thousand people), and the assumption that they make 3 images per day, we can crunch the numbers.

53,000 x 3 = 159,000

159,000 ÷ 26 = 6115.

For reference, an apartment complex uses about 2,150 gallons of water a day. While this may not seem as big of a difference, you have to consider that there are over 6,111 public data centers worldwide.

6,115 x 6,111 = 37,368,765.

Now while currently AI probably uses less than all apartment complexes combined, long term it can be a real waste. Along with increased need for things like RAM, GPUs and other computer parts, it can end up increasing the prices of computer parts drastically.

Also, while the water used by apartment complexes are generally used for things like cooking, cleaning, or drinking in general, all very needed things, AI nowadays is used for generating images, text, videos, and occasionally coding or other things.

TL:DR, AI in general uses an estimate of 37,368,765 gallons of water per day, or 6,115 gallons per data center on useless things (sometimes). Long term use will lead to rises in prices for computer parts, and Microsoft will eventually own the Great Lakes before Nestle does.

(PS, sorry for low quality. I had to change a few things in order for the moderators to be happy with my post.)

Comments

> **u/o_herman** • 2 points • 2026-01-25 07:36 UTC
>
> This math is fundamentally wrong at every step.
>
> 1. There is no such thing as “1 image = 1 toilet flush.” Cooling water is amortized across millions of requests and reused in loops - it is not consumed per inference.
> 2. Dividing “number of images” by “cups per flush” to get gallons is dimensionally invalid. That’s not how units work.
> 3. Multiplying by *all public data centers worldwide* is pure fiction - only a small subset run inference workloads.
> 4. Data center cooling water is mostly recirculated or reclaimed, not flushed like household water.
> 5. The GPU price claim has no causal link to water usage.
>
> What this calculation does: It’s inventing numbers, breaking units, and inflating by 3–4 orders of magnitude.
>
> Also, water use isn’t connected to RAM shortages, GPU prices, or silicon supply. Those issues are driven by factors like wafer capacity, HBM yield, packaging limits, and export controls. In other words, water scarcity doesn’t cause GPU prices to go up.
>
> A single hamburger or hour of Netflix uses more water than thousands of AI inferences.
>
>> **u/CryptographerKlutzy7** • 1 points • 2026-01-25 07:45 UTC
>>
>> Yeah, the analysis starting with "This is based off the assumption that an AI image uses about as much water as a toilet flush." is a pretty big sign that OP is going to be pulling lots of numbers out of their arse, and isn't going to get anything remotely right.

> **u/AutoModerator** • 1 points • 2026-01-25 07:25 UTC
>
> This is an automated reminder from the Mod team. If your post contains images which reveal the personal information of private figures, be sure to censor that information and repost. Private info includes names, recognizable profile pictures, social media usernames and URLs. Failure to do this will result in your post being removed by the Mod team and possible further action.
>
> *I am a bot, and this action was performed automatically. Please [contact the moderators of this subreddit](/message/compose/?to=/r/aiwars) if you have any questions or concerns.*